SERMON AUDIT

It Still Works | Pastor Steven Furtick | Elevation Church

Pastor Steven Furtick · Elevation Church · 2026-04-19 · 00:50:18

Preaching text: · *Gospel translation:* ESV

Video: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=ccNvwDPguNU

Scorecard

FIDELITY TO JESUS'S TEACHINGS (RED LETTERS)

Mostly on-topic; mechanism-faith tension

Three flagged items — a formulaic 'it works if you work it' framing sits in tension with Jesus's Gethsemane prayer and Matt 26:39; flippant 'at least you didn't kill them' about children cuts against Matt 18:6; political aside is fleeting.

IDENTIFIABLE BIASES / HARMFUL RHETORIC

Largely absent

No identifiable CN markers beyond a one-line 'politics' aside. No anti-Muslim, anti-LGBTQ, anti-Jewish, or misogynistic framing. One low-severity concern: unprompted mention of suicidal ideation ('do it with suicidal thoughts, but do it') is pastorally thin — meant to encourage but delivered without any referral to care.

FACTUAL CLAIMS & EVIDENCE CHECK

Light on empirical claims; biblical citations largely accurate

The sermon is mostly exhortation, not argument from facts. Biblical chronology claims (430 years in Egypt; 40 years in Midian; Moses' name etymology) are either biblically supported or reflect the Bible's own folk-etymology. One testimony (Greenville suicide intervention via podcast) is unverifiable by design.

WHOLE-BIBLE ENGAGEMENT

Narrow lane, minor cherry-pick on suffering

Furtick preaches one book (Exodus) consistently but narrates faith as mechanism ('it works if you work it') without engaging the substantial canonical witness — Job, Ecclesiastes, the Psalms of lament, Jesus in Gethsemane, Heb 11:35–39 — where faith emphatically does not 'work' in the sense the sermon implies.

Summary

Furtick preaches a 50-minute motivational exposition of Exodus 4, repeating the refrain "It still works" roughly forty times. The through-line: Moses doubted, delayed, and complained but God used him anyway — therefore the listener's doubts, delays, and bad attitudes do not disqualify them. The sermon's signature move is a prop bit where Furtick plays a 26-year-old cassette of his own preaching through a refurbished boombox to argue that "the method changes but the message is the same." He closes with a testimony of a man in Greenville, SC, who (per Furtick) set down a 9mm after hearing a Furtick podcast sermon. The sermon is largely apolitical and contains no identifiable Christian-nationalist, anti-Muslim, anti-LGBTQ, or anti-Jewish rhetoric. The main analytical concerns are (1) a formulaic "it works if you work it" framing of faith that edges toward mechanism/prosperity, (2) a flippant aside about child discipline ("at least you didn't kill them… God will fix it"), (3) a monetized-giving pitch framed as "weird but it works," and (4) handling of suicidal ideation as something to "do doubting" without referral to care.

Timeline

Each marker = a flagged finding. Click to jump to the finding; hover for the title. Color indicates severity.

00:00:00 00:50:18

Findings (5)

MODERATE | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:35:00 | HEADLINE

Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

Why flagged: Jesus's own model of faith culminates in a prayer that is not answered in the way the petitioner requests — the cup does not pass — and in a cry of forsakenness quoting a Hebrew psalm of lament. A refrain insisting that prayer/faith/praise 'still works' if you 'work it' — extended across every domain the listener might bring — sits uneasily against the canonical picture in which the Son himself prays a prayer that does not 'work' in those terms, precisely so that something larger than mechanism can happen.

PASTOR

And it works if you work it... Won't it work? I said, 'Won't it work?' Not if you don't work it... It'll work when you're old. It'll work in this season. It'll work when they like you. It'll work when they hate you. It'll work when they lie about you. It'll work when they leave you.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Matt 26:39 (Gethsemane)

My Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as you will.

Matt 6:10

Your kingdom come, your will be done, on earth as it is in heaven.

John 11:21, 32 (Martha and Mary to Jesus about Lazarus)

Lord, if you had been here, my brother would not have died.

Mark 15:34 — Jesus citing Ps 22:1 from the cross

Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?' which means, 'My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?'

MODERATE | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:11:30

Flippant aside about child discipline

Why flagged: Aimed as a comedic laugh-line about parental blow-ups, the framing sets a floor ('not killing' your kids) so low that it functionally dismisses the range of harms short of homicide that Jesus treats as grave. Matt 18:6 sets a drastically different calibration. The joke also misappropriates Prov 22:6 as a guarantee (it is a proverb, not a warranty) to relieve the parent of responsibility for the 'blew up at the kids' behavior just invoked. Low-to-moderate severity pastoral miscalibration to a mass audience likely to include survivors of parental abuse.

PASTOR

Well, at least you didn't kill them. I mean, at least they're still here. The Bible says if you train up a child in the way they should go, when they're old they won't depart from it. That means all you've got to do is not kill them, and God will fix it. In the meantime, just let them live.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Matt 18:6

Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him to have a great millstone fastened around his neck and to be drowned in the depth of the sea.

Matt 19:14

Let the little children come to me and do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of heaven.

Mark 9:42

Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him if a great millstone were hung around his neck and he were thrown into the sea.

LOW | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:07:00

Political aside conflating church unity with partisan discourse

Why flagged: Very low-severity finding — a single aside, not a theme. But the sentence assumes 'we' (Christians, or Americans) are all 'supposed to be on the same side,' a framing that flattens genuine moral disagreement into a unity-against-other posture. Jesus's own pattern with unity language is intra-ecclesial (John 17), not civic, and he repeatedly declines the role of civic arbitrator (Luke 12). Included here for coverage, not because it drives the sermon.

PASTOR

I wish we could preach some of that in politics today. I wish we could preach some of that in the church today. 'You're supposed to be on the same side. Really? Y'all are fighting?'

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

John 17:21

That they may all be one, just as you, Father, are in me, and I in you, that they also may be in us, so that the world may believe that you have sent me.

Matt 5:23–24

So if you are offering your gift at the altar and there remember that your brother has something against you, leave your gift there before the altar and go. First be reconciled to your brother, and then come and offer your gift.

Luke 12:13–14

Teacher, tell my brother to divide the inheritance with me.' But he said to him, 'Man, who made me a judge or arbitrator over you?'

LOW | AXIS 1 | ▶ 00:38:00

Tithing/giving framed as 'weird but it works' mechanism

Why flagged: Jesus's teaching on giving is overwhelmingly directed toward the poor, the hungry, the stranger, and 'the least of these' — not toward institutional maintenance framed in the possessive ('our church'). Using the sermon's central 'it works' mechanism to authenticate tithing to the preaching institution itself is low-severity but notable. The Gospel counter-witness would route the mechanism outward (the poor) rather than inward (the church organization reaching 'the world' through its platform).

PASTOR

It's weird for us to give to God so that our church can do outreaches, so that our church can reach the world, so that our church can preach the gospel. That is weird, but you find out that God doesn't need what you have; you need what he has when you give, and it allows you to access your faith... people are like, 'You give your money to that church?' 'No. I give it to God through a church.'... So that's weird, but it works.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Matt 6:2–4

When you give to the needy, sound no trumpet before you, as the hypocrites do in the synagogues and in the streets, that they may be praised by others... But when you give to the needy, do not let your left hand know what your right hand is doing.

Mark 12:41–44 (the widow's mite)

And he sat down opposite the treasury and watched the people putting money into the offering box. Many rich people put in large sums... she out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on.

Matt 25:35–40

For I was hungry and you gave me food, I was thirsty and you gave me drink, I was a stranger and you welcomed me... as you did it to one of the least of these my brothers, you did it to me.

LOW | AXIS 2 | ▶ 00:15:30

Suicidal ideation addressed without referral to care

Why flagged: The intent is pastoral affirmation — 'stay alive' — and is counted here as a counter-signal as well. But addressing an audience including people with active suicidal ideation from a mega-church pulpit and reducing the prescription to 'do it anyway' — without naming 988, a counseling referral, or any non-'work it yourself' route — is pastorally thin. Low severity because the directional effect is pro-life, but flagged so that the sermon's mass reach gets the benefit of the fuller canonical posture (Matt 11) in which the heavily-laden are pointed toward help, not just told to push through.

PASTOR

Do it doubting, but do it. Do it afraid, but do it. Do it with suicidal thoughts, but do it. Live another day thinking you don't deserve to be on the earth, but live another day. Take another breath feeling anxious, but take another breath.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS

Matt 11:28–30

Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest. Take my yoke upon you, and learn from me, for I am gentle and lowly in heart, and you will find rest for your souls.

Luke 10:34 (the Good Samaritan — actively transporting a wounded stranger to a place of care)

He went to him and bound up his wounds, pouring on oil and wine. Then he set him on his own animal and brought him to an inn and took care of him.

Whole-Bible Engagement (2)

For each major framing in the sermon, the pastor's claim is placed side-by-side with **what Jesus said in the Gospels** and **what the wider Bible says** (OT + NT non-Gospel). Surfaces cherry-picking, omitted counter-voices, and places where the canon itself contains tension the pastor did not acknowledge.

MODERATE | AXIS 4 | ▶ 00:33:30 | HEADLINE

Faith as 'it works' — mechanism without the canonical lament tradition

TOPIC: WHAT FAITH LOOKS LIKE WHEN IT DOESN'T PRODUCE THE OUTCOME SOUGHT

Why flagged: The sermon's load-bearing refrain is a formula ('it works if you work it') that the canon explicitly and repeatedly qualifies — including in Jesus's own prayer life. A mass-audience pastor can affirm that God is faithful without adopting a mechanism frame the canon itself resists.

CANONICAL ANALYSIS

The biblical canon contains a substantial tradition — Job, Ecclesiastes, roughly one third of the Psalter (the laments), Lamentations, and Hebrews 11:35–39 — that is precisely about faith when it does not 'work' in the sense the sermon invokes. Jesus himself prays a Gethsemane prayer that does not 'work' (the cup does not pass) and quotes Ps 22's opening line of forsakenness from the cross. Paul is denied three times when he asks for the thorn's removal. Hebrews 11, the canonical faith chapter, ends by insisting that some faithful people were 'stoned… sawn in two… killed with the sword' and 'did not receive what was promised.' Furtick's refrain — extended to panic attacks, dry seasons, enemies, leavers — isn't heretical; prayer, worship, and praise are valuable regardless of outcome. But by framing faith exclusively through 'it works' he leaves the listener without the canonical vocabulary for the time when, by any ordinary human reckoning, it doesn't. No reference to Gethsemane. No reference to the laments. No reference to Hebrews 11:35–39. The narrow lane is the Moses-gets-the-deliverance arc, generalized into a formula.

PASTOR

Faith still works. Faith still works. Grace still works. Gratitude still works. 'Hallelujah' still works. 'Thank you, Jesus' still works. It still works!… It'll get you through the dry season. It'll get you through the panic attack. It'll get you through it, because it still works.

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS (GOSPELS)

Matt 26:38–39 (Gethsemane)

My soul is very sorrowful, even to death; remain here, and watch with me… My Father, if it be possible, let this cup pass from me; nevertheless, not as I will, but as you will.

Mark 15:34 — Jesus citing Ps 22:1 from the cross

My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?

John 11:33–35

When Jesus saw her weeping… he was deeply moved in his spirit and greatly troubled… Jesus wept.

Luke 13:1–5 (when told of Pilate's massacre)

Do you think that these Galileans were worse sinners than all the other Galileans, because they suffered in this way? No, I tell you… unless you repent, you will all likewise perish.

WIDER BIBLE (OT & NT NON-GOSPEL)

Job 23:8–9

Behold, I go forward, but he is not there, and backward, but I do not perceive him; on the left hand when he is working, I do not behold him; he turns to the right hand, but I do not see him.

Eccl 9:11

Again I saw that under the sun the race is not to the swift, nor the battle to the strong, nor bread to the wise, nor riches to the intelligent, nor favor to those with knowledge, but time and chance happen to them all.

Ps 88:18 (a psalm of lament that ends without resolution)

You have caused my beloved and my friend to shun me; my companions have become darkness.

Heb 11:35–39

Some were tortured, refusing to accept release, so that they might rise again to a better life. Others suffered mocking and flogging, and even chains and imprisonment. They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they were killed with the sword… And all these, though commended through their faith, did not receive what was promised.

2 Cor 12:8–9 (Paul)

Three times I pleaded with the Lord about this, that it should leave me. But he said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for my power is made perfect in weakness.'

Rom 8:18, 22–23

> For I consider that the sufferings of this present time are not worth comparing with the glory that is to be revealed to us… For we know that the whole creation has been groaning together in the pains of childbirth until now. And not only the creation, but we ourselves… groan inwardly.

LOW | AXIS 4 | ▶ 00:12:00

Doubt reframed as fuel — but without the canonical warnings

TOPIC: HOW SCRIPTURE EVALUATES PERSISTENT DOUBT AND DIVIDED MIND

Why flagged: The sermon draws heavily from the doubt-accommodating Gospel strand (which is real) while adopting an 'it works if you work it' mechanism that the doubt-warning strand (James 1:6–8; Rom 14:23) explicitly gates behind undivided faith. Either strand is defensible; the combination needs the tension named.

CANONICAL ANALYSIS

The canon is genuinely in tension on doubt. Jesus's pastoral posture with Thomas, with the 'I believe; help my unbelief' father, and with the Matt 28:17 worshipers-who-doubted is accommodating and gentle — he accepts the mixed state and works within it. That matches Furtick's point well. But the other canonical voice — James 1:6–8 in particular — is sharp: the double-minded person 'must not suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord.' Paul in Rom 14:23 is also sharp. Furtick is not wrong to highlight the Jesus-with-Thomas strand; he is on solid Gospel ground. The gap is that he doesn't acknowledge that the wider canon contains a harsher counter-voice — which, notably, lives inside the very mechanism ('ask in faith and you will receive') the sermon's 'it works' refrain is extending. If the mechanism is right, James's warning about the double-minded is also right. Furtick wants the mechanism and the doubt-permission simultaneously; the canon makes you pay for that by at least naming the tension.

PASTOR

The first point of my message is sometimes you've got to do it doubting… Sometimes great faith is not eliminating doubt; it is looking at doubt right in the face and telling doubt, 'You can sit in the passenger seat, but you can't drive, because we're doing this.'

Jump to transcript ↓

JESUS (GOSPELS)

Mark 9:23–24

All things are possible for one who believes.' Immediately the father of the child cried out and said, 'I believe; help my unbelief!'

Matt 14:31 (to Peter sinking)

O you of little faith, why did you doubt?

John 20:27 (to Thomas)

Put your finger here, and see my hands; and put out your hand, and place it in my side. Do not disbelieve, but believe.

Matt 28:17 (at the Great Commission scene)

And when they saw him they worshiped him, but some doubted.

WIDER BIBLE (OT & NT NON-GOSPEL)

James 1:6–8

But let him ask in faith, with no doubting, for the one who doubts is like a wave of the sea that is driven and tossed by the wind. For that person must not suppose that he will receive anything from the Lord; he is a double-minded man, unstable in all his ways.

Jude 22

And have mercy on those who doubt.

Rom 14:23

But whoever has doubts is condemned if he eats, because the eating is not from faith. For whatever does not proceed from faith is sin.

2 Cor 5:7

For we walk by faith, not by sight.

Factual Claims & Evidence Check (4)

Empirical claims the pastor made during the sermon, with a verdict on whether independent evidence supports them. Verdict scale: Supported · Partially supported · Contested · Misleading · Unsupported · False. “Evidence the pastor cited” records whether any source was named in the sermon itself.

SUPPORTED ▶ 00:27:00

“The people of Israel had been enslaved for four centuries (430 years) in Egypt.”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

The people of Israel had been enslaved for four centuries (430 years) in Egypt.

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None explicitly; delivered as a biblical aside.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

This is directly supported by the Hebrew Bible's own chronology: Exodus 12:40 states, 'The time that the people of Israel lived in Egypt was 430 years.' Genesis 15:13 also gives a round number of 400 years for the affliction. (Scholarly/historical dating of the events is contested, but Furtick's claim is a biblical-chronology claim, and on its own terms the text supports it.)

SOURCES CONSULTED

- Exodus 12:40 (ESV) — Bible Gateway

PARTIALLY SUPPORTED ▶ 00:07:30

“Moses' name means 'drawn out of water.'”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

Moses' name means 'drawn out of water.'

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None; delivered as a biblical fact.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

This is the folk-etymology the Bible itself gives in Exodus 2:10: Pharaoh's daughter 'named him Moses, saying, "Because I drew him out of the water."' However, most contemporary Egyptologists and Hebrew Bible scholars note that the name is more likely Egyptian in origin, related to the root 'msj' meaning 'to give birth to' or 'son' — as in Thutmose ('son of Thoth') or Ramesses ('son of Ra'). The Hebrew verb māšâ ('to draw out') is a plausible Hebrew folk etymology overlaid on an Egyptian name. Furtick's claim tracks the biblical text's own self-interpretation; it is supported on the Bible's terms and partially supported on scholarly terms.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- Exodus 2:10 (ESV) — Bible Gateway

SUPPORTED ▶ 00:21:00

“Paul and Silas were fastened in the inner cell — 'the hardest place to get out of' — and they sang at midnight.”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

Paul and Silas were fastened in the inner cell — 'the hardest place to get out of' — and they sang at midnight.

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

None cited; delivered as a biblical aside.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

Directly supported by Acts 16:24–25: 'Having received this order, he put them into the inner prison and fastened their feet in the stocks. About midnight Paul and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the prisoners were listening to them.' The characterization is faithful to the text.

SOURCES CONSULTED

- Acts 16:24–25 (ESV) — Bible Gateway

NEEDS VERIFICATION ▶ 00:40:00

“A man in Greenville, SC, with a 9mm handgun on his coffee table during a divorce, plugged in an Apple TV his mother h...”

PASTOR'S CLAIM (FULL)

A man in Greenville, SC, with a 9mm handgun on his coffee table during a divorce, plugged in an Apple TV his mother had brought over, clicked a purple 'Podcast' icon, then an orange 'Elevation' icon, and heard a Furtick sermon called 'Handle It' preached ten years prior; he subsequently became a worship leader at a local church.

EVIDENCE THE PASTOR CITED

Furtick attributes it to 'a testimony I heard the other day' from the man himself. No name, no date, no independent documentation offered.

WHAT THE EVIDENCE SHOWS

This is an uncorroborated pastoral testimony. Key unverifiable elements: (1) the man's identity is withheld, so the account cannot be checked; (2) the claimed Apple TV UI behavior (a purple 'Podcast' icon, a separate orange 'Elevation' icon) does not cleanly match the standard Apple TV interface — Apple's Podcasts app icon is purple, but there is no standalone 'Elevation' app in the Apple TV App Store that surfaces as a top-level colored tile to a user who has never used the platform before; Elevation content is typically distributed via the Podcasts app, YouTube, and third-party channels. (3) Furtick has preached material titled 'Handle It' touching Exodus 4, and the sermon frames 'It Still Works' as a callback to that earlier message, but I cannot independently confirm the exact 10-year delta or the testimony chain. What would need to be checked: the existence and date of the 'Handle It' sermon in Elevation's public archive; whether Elevation has a named/consented version of this testimony; and the plausibility of the UI description. The underlying pastoral point can stand on its own, but the specific event as narrated is not verifiable from public sources.

Tenets affirmed

- Exposition of Exodus 4 tracks the text accurately: Moses' objection (4:1), the staff-to-snake sign (4:2–4), the two-handed divine assurance (4:17), and the return to Egypt (4:19–20) are all rendered faithfully.

- Acknowledges doubt, fear, and bad attitudes as normal rather than disqualifying in the life of faith — consonant with biblical figures from Moses (Ex 4) to Thomas (John 20) to the father in Mark 9:24.
- Correctly identifies Paul and Silas's midnight praise in the 'inner cell' (Acts 16:24–25) and the pattern of worship preceding deliverance.
- Repeatedly tells hearers who feel suicidal or worthless to 'live another day' and 'take another breath' — pastoral affirmation of life.

Counter-signals

- No political party, candidate, or policy is named or targeted from the pulpit; the lone political reference ('I wish we could preach some of that in politics today') is a throwaway aside without partisan direction.
- No anti-Muslim, anti-LGBTQ, anti-Jewish, or misogynistic framing detected in the sermon.
- Self-deprecating posture throughout — Furtick names his own long-running preaching anxiety ('my hands were shaking while I held my pen'; 'I didn't know anything I was talking about') rather than posturing as a prophetic strongman.
- Affirms life directly to listeners with suicidal ideation ('live another day'; 'take another breath').
- Explicit multi-campus inclusion (Houston shout-out; YouTube audience from named states) without ethno-cultural 'real American' coding.
- Acknowledges that past methods (tapes, CDs, Campobello small-church preaching) were not inferior to current platform reach — a non-triumphalist note about church growth.

Christian Nationalism marker rubric (Whitehead/Perry, Du Mez, Alberta)

MARKER	STATUS	NOTES
A. Conflation of national & Christian identity	None detected	No America-as-chosen-nation rhetoric; no flag imagery; no national-favor framing.
B. Militaristic / warrior framing	None detected	Staff/snake/plague imagery is used exegetically for Moses, not transposed onto a present-day culture war.
C. Political opponents as spiritual enemies	None detected	
D. Dominionist rhetoric	None detected	
E. Civil religion (flag, pledge)	None detected	

MARKER	STATUS	NOTES
F. Jeremiad / 'Christianity under attack'	None detected	No persecution narrative; the sermon's adversary is private doubt, not cultural hostility.
G. Ethno-cultural 'real American' undertones	None detected	Multi-state/multi-city YouTube roll call is geographically inclusive.
H. Strongman / authoritarian affinity	None detected	

Other Axis-2 sub-rubrics

- **Anti-Muslim framing:** Not present in this sermon
- **Anti-LGBTQ framing:** Not present — A single chastity reference ('You're a virgin? That's weird. No. It works') is directed generally, not targeted at any identity group.
- **Misogynistic framing:** Not present — Passing 'God just deals with Jezebel' idiom is used of an external obstacle in the pastor's own story, not of women generally.
- **Anti-Jewish framing / supersessionism:** Not present — Exodus narrative is read as the Bible's own deliverance story; the typological reading of Jesus as 'our true Moses' (00:23:00) is Christological without denigrating Jewish identity.

Full transcript

Highlighted paragraphs contain flagged content (color = severity). Click any timestamp to jump to that moment on YouTube.

[00:00:00] How many are ready for the Word of God today? Hey, hey, we've got 2,000 people in Houston, Texas.   Let's welcome them. How many in Houston are ready for the Word of God today? Yes, Lord. It's going   to be a good day. And you know how you can know that? Look who you're sitting next to. Why would   God sit you next to somebody that good-looking if it wasn't going to be a good day? Praise the Lord.

[00:00:30] I am going to be sharing today from Exodus, chapter 4. Please remain standing for the Word   of God. "The grass withers, the flower fades, but the Word of the Lord stands forever." Y'all need   to learn the Bible better so you can quote it when I quote it. "The grass withers, the flower fades,   but the Word of the Lord stands forever." Amen. The Word of the Lord in Exodus, chapter 4,   may be a familiar Scripture, but there is one thing I want to highlight for your life today. By the way, if you're watching online, just put in the comments, "I'm here." Let us know that you're

[00:01:00] joining too. And if you're here in person, just go ahead and shout it at me too. Say,   "I'm here. I'm awake. I had my coffee, and I want a breakthrough." All right. When we see this meeting in Exodus, chapter 4, we are walking into the middle of a mess. That's

[00:01:30] where God likes to work the most. Exodus 4:1: "Moses answered, 'What if they do not believe   me or listen to me and say, "The Lord did not appear to you"?' Then the Lord said to him,   'What is that in your hand?' 'A staff,' he replied. The Lord said, 'Throw it on the ground.'"

[00:02:00] I feel like he probably hollered at him, because it's a pretty weird thing he's asking him to do   here, so the Lord said it with confidence. "Throw it on the ground." "Moses threw it on   the ground and it became a snake..." Uh-oh. This is getting worse, not better. When your staff   becomes a snake, it looks like you're going backward when you need God to comfort you. "'A staff,' he replied. The Lord said, 'Throw it on the ground.' Moses threw it on the ground and   it became a snake, and he ran from it." Well, that makes sense. I would do that too. "Then the Lord

[00:02:30] said to him, 'Reach out your hand and take it by the tail.' So Moses reached out and took hold of   the snake and it turned back into a staff in his hand. 'This,' said the Lord, 'is so that   they may believe that the Lord, the God of their fathers—the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and

[00:03:00] the God of Jacob...'" "This is so that they may believe that that God has appeared to you." Now, drop down, please, to verse 17, because God gives him two more signs to show him   that he's with him, that he's to perform in the palace before Pharaoh and in the desert   before the Israelites, but Moses argues with God. He even tries to say, "I'm not a very   good speaker. How can I tell Pharaoh to let your people go when I'm not even eloquent?" Well, the Lord said, "I'm not asking you to take a speech class; I'm asking you to take a faith step,

[00:03:30] because I don't need your ability; I need your availability." Who is that for today?   Right. Right. Right. Right. But let me show you one more thing. When God tells Moses,   "Well, I'm going to give you your brother Aaron. He's going to help you since you can't   do it alone. I've already got your partner lined up..." Watch this in verse 17. He says,   "But take this staff in your hand so you can perform the signs with it."

[00:04:00] "So you can perform the signs with it." Then go to   verse 19. "Now the Lord had said to Moses in Midian, 'Go back to Egypt,   for all those who wanted to kill you are dead.' So Moses took his wife and sons, put them on a   donkey and started back to Egypt. And he took the staff of God in his hand." I love that. Today, the Lord told me to give you a word, and the word is this: It Still Works. It still works.

[00:04:30] Hallelujah. God woke me up this morning at 4:00 in the morning and said, "Just get ready to tell   somebody, 'It still works.'" So, I've got good news for you today. In spite of what it is that   has been reverberating in your ear, causing you to fear, the Lord said, "It still works."

[00:05:00] Touch all seven people you can reach and say, "It still works."   It still works. It still works. You may be seated. On your way to your seat, shout,   "It still works!" Mm-hmm. It still works. Let's talk about this for a moment. What   a job. Right? We understand Moses' hesitation because we understand that he's over his head.

[00:05:30] "You mean you want me to go to the most powerful man in the world and tell him to let your people   go who have been in Egypt for 430 years? Wow." We understand his hesitation. We have grace for   Moses' need for clarification when he says, "What if they don't believe in me?" I mean,   of course you would wonder that if they had rejected you 40 years earlier.

[00:06:00] Do you remember how the story of Moses begins? He's put in a basket,   and he is discovered by Pharaoh's daughter, but he is raised as an Egyptian. So,   he is Egyptian by background, but he's Hebrew by birth. This presents a conflict,   because to be an Egyptian is one thing, to be a Hebrew is another,   but Moses is both. Because Moses is both, he is uniquely positioned to do this job.

[00:06:30] But Moses, like many of us, has been spending years of his life paying the price of regret for   a mistake he made earlier with a passion he did not know how to manage, because God had put it in   his heart for a long time to help his people, but one day, when he saw an Egyptian beating a Hebrew   slave, he killed the Egyptian and hid him in the sand. The next day, two Hebrews were fighting,   and he said, "Why are y'all fighting?   Y'all are supposed to be on the same side."

[00:07:00] I wish we could preach some of that in politics today. I wish we could preach some of that in   the church today. "You're supposed to be on the same side. Really? Y'all are fighting?"   One of them turned to him with an attitude and said, "Are you going to kill me like you did   the Egyptian?" And Moses ran to Midian, because he said, "What I did must have become known." He ran and he ran and he ran and he ran until a well appeared. Moses' name means   drawn out of water. Isn't it interesting that he met his wife drawing water for her from a   → Political aside conflating church unity with partisan discourse

[00:07:30] well? He finds out that her father's name is Jethro, and he settles in tending sheep   for Jethro. But now God has a job for Moses that is bigger than Jethro, and God says,   "I need you to go." Moses said, "I don't know if they'll believe this. First of all,   who am I to go to Pharaoh? And secondly, who are you? What do I tell them about all of this?" → Political aside conflating church unity with partisan discourse

[00:08:00] So, as we settle into the text, we understand that it's a mess,   because Moses is a murderer who's being turned into a messenger. That's always messy when   God gives you an assignment that contradicts your current understanding of your identity,   because whenever God gives you something to do, you will try to overlay who you think you are   onto what he has called you to do. But Moses is about to find out that God works in crazy ways. Now, as much as I respect Moses' decision to do what God called him to do, we need to be direct

[00:08:30] about the fact that he doubted God. He doubted God so much that God became angry with him,   but God's anger did not cancel the assignment. God simply sent him forward in power as he   leaned on his staff. I'm going to talk about the staff in a moment,   but I want to make this personal first of all. A few years ago, I had something that God had called me to do,

[00:09:00] and I became very intimidated about it. I had a bad attitude about it,   but I did it anyway. After I did it, I was driving home, and God had so handled all   the things I was worried about that I didn't even have to deal with them when I got there. So, I felt grateful, but I also felt guilty,   because I had made it to be this huge thing in my mind. I mean,   how many of you have done this before? I made it to be this huge thing in my mind. Like, "Oh,

[00:09:30] I've got to call my coach and tell him I'm not coming back next year, and my coach is going to   kill me." Your coach isn't going to kill you. Your coach is just going to say, "Thank you." But you make it out to be this huge thing in your mind. You make it out to be something   so much bigger than it is. Then, a lot of times, God just deals with Jezebel,   and you never even have to. It almost made me feel so guilty about my attitude that   I couldn't even enjoy the achievement of doing the thing God had called me to do.

[00:10:00] It's like when you take your kids on a vacation,   but now you're going to have to send them to therapy to deal with the way you acted   on vacation. Come on, talk to me. Talk to me or I'll prophesy! It's the feeling of, like,   "God, I'm so sorry." So, I was coming home in my car, and it just went so beautifully,   but I had been so burdened about it, and I just felt bad about it. I couldn't even enjoy   how good it went because I felt so guilty. I was like, "I had such a bad attitude."

[00:10:30] And the Lord showed me something. Sometimes great faith is taking the right action with   a bad attitude. I'm going to say it again for the note takers. Sometimes great faith   is taking the right action with a bad attitude. As I was praying to the Lord,   I was like, "I'm so sorry I had such a bad attitude. You took care of it. You handled   it. I didn't even have to worry about it, God. I was so worried. I was so stressed.

[00:11:00] I complained so much, and then you just did it. I'm so sorry, God, that I doubted you." It was like the Lord spoke to me. He said, "You're embarrassed because you doubted.   I'm proud because you did it." I don't know who it's for, but the heart of the Father   wanted to say that to you today. You have been beating yourself up so much about your doubts   that you are not even celebrating how much you have done and how far you have come and

> [00:11:30] how many ways you have changed, because all you keep focusing on is "God, I'm so sorry   that I had such a bad attitude. God, I'm so sorry that I blew up at the kids like that." Well, at least you didn't kill them. I mean,   at least they're still here. The Bible says if you train up a child in the way they should go,   when they're old they won't depart from it. That means all you've got to do is not kill them,   and God will fix it. In the meantime, just let them live. Somebody shout, "Let them live." → Flippant aside about child discipline

[00:12:00] Some days that's all you can do is just to say, "Hey, I didn't do that perfectly, but I did it."   The first point of my message is sometimes you've got to do it doubting. Sometimes   you've got to do it doubting. Notice in the text that Moses' first response to the assignment is   not gratitude. Moses' first response to the assignment is not to receive it but to run. Just in case you're dealing with something in your life right now, and you're looking   → Flippant aside about child discipline; Doubt reframed as fuel — but without the canonical warnings

[00:12:30] at it like a snake on the ground that God has told you to grab by the tail, that's okay.   It is natural to run from something you have never seen in this form before. I am   concerned that you are beating yourself up so much about your fear that you have not   properly contextualized the magnitude of the faith it took for you to be where you are. A fellow told me one time, "I don't like when I go to church when the preacher just tells me   → Doubt reframed as fuel — but without the canonical warnings

[00:13:00] I'm doing good and makes me feel good. I just need the preacher to step on my toes. You know,   man, just slap me in the face, man. Just spank me a little bit." I'm like, "Dude,   that's not my gig. I don't know what you... You need to call somebody else for all that you just   mentioned." Maybe it's because everything I ever did for God, I did it doubting.

[00:13:30] Every sermon I ever preached to you, my hands were shaking while I held   my pen. I'll show you my handwriting, and you'll believe me then. You'll say,   "Pastor Steven would have been a serial killer in another life. Look at that handwriting."   You'd be psychoanalyzing me. No, it's because I had to do it doubting. You know, Graham,   I think Exodus 4:1 is my whole preaching life verse, because this is the verse I've   felt the most preaching up here. "What if they don't believe me or listen to me?"

[00:14:00] I wish my biggest preaching verse was Isaiah 6:8. "Here am I. Send me." But really,   my preaching verse, how I feel, is "What if they don't believe me or listen to me?"   I want to start this sermon this way, because I'm going to encourage you in   a moment about the things in your life that look impossible to you right now. Let me be   less vague than that. The current thing in your life that you are doubting about.

[00:14:30] I don't even necessarily mean you're doubting God. You might just be doubting you. I don't   even mean you doubt that God is good; I just mean you feel like you are not good enough.   Everything I have

ever done for God I have never felt good enough to do. So, do with that   what you will. Judge me if you want to. Make fun of me if you want. Tell me that I should   have more confidence in Christ if you must. But everything I ever did for God I did it doubting.

[00:15:00] Every song I ever wrote from the Lord I did feeling like a bad singer. Every chord I ever   strummed to write a hymn for our church to sing I did it wishing I knew more music theory. You don't   understand what I'm saying. Everything I ever did for God... Every time I ever played back one   of my preaching clips and listened to it, I had to cringe to find the clip because I didn't even   like the way I sounded. Everything I ever did for God I did it doubting. But I did it. But I did it.

> [00:15:30] Sometimes great faith is not eliminating doubt; it is looking at doubt right in the face and telling   doubt, "You can sit in the passenger seat, but you can't drive, because we're doing this." High-five   somebody and say, "I'm doing this." There's a whole word in this right now. Do it doubting,   but do it. Do it afraid, but do it. Do it with suicidal thoughts, but do it. → Suicidal ideation addressed without referral to care

> [00:16:00] Live another day thinking you don't deserve to be on the earth, but live another day.   Take another breath feeling anxious, but take another breath. Give God a praise not   feeling a goose bump, but lift your hands. Lift your hands with your shoulder hurting,   but lift your hands. Lift your hands with a bad back, but lift your hands. Do it. And I'll tell you something. Worship will work whether you feel it or not. I said,   "Worship will work whether you feel it or not."   → Suicidal ideation addressed without referral to care

[00:16:30] Tell somebody, "It'll work." It'll work. Worship still works. Worship still works when it's the   middle of the night and there's nobody around to listen to you cry, and you cry out to God, saying,   "When my heart is overwhelmed, lead me to the rock that is higher than I." It'll work. It'll work. I know it will work, because the people of God in Exodus, chapter 4, had been enslaved

[00:17:00] for four centuries, and Moses has been in exile for four decades. But this text pops up into the   transitional moment to remind us that it still works. Because God said to Moses (watch this),   "The cries of my people have reached heaven." What's he saying? "I heard.   I heard." And even as the burdens of the people grew heavier, God says, "I heard."

[00:17:30] See, you think when it doesn't happen God didn't hear. So, for all of those years that   Moses tended sheep and thought, "It's over; I blew it..." For all those years that you thought,   "If I could just go back and do it different, I would..." For all those years that you have   thought it was over... For all those years that the people prayed, "God, send us a deliverer. God,   send us a sign. God, set us free," God came down to Moses to say, "It worked."

[00:18:00] So, I want to remind you today that your prayers aren't pointless, even if you don't have proof   that they're heard. Please write that down and put it somewhere you can see it when the   Enemy tries to tell you it's not working this week. "My prayers are not pointless,   even if I have no proof they have been heard." God might be multitasking some things in your life   right now. God might be setting some things up for a generation from now that you don't know about.

[00:18:30] God might need you to help somebody in the future, so you've got to go through hell right   now so you can help them later. God heard you. Oh, I feel anointed today. I'm not even saying   I'm anointed for everybody in the room. Maybe just for three people. Maybe for 300. Maybe   for somebody in the back. Maybe for somebody in overflow. But the Lord said, "It's not pointless."   My prayers are not pointless because my God has a plan.

[00:19:00] Keep praying for your babies. Keep praying about what's going on that the doctors can't   figure out. Keep praying about it. It's not pointless. This is what Exodus 4 teaches me,   that God's lack of activity does not mean God's absence.   Just because he is not active in the way that I have prescribed for him to   be does not mean his purpose isn't working. It still works. Say it again. "It still works."

[00:19:30] This sermon has three points, but it's really only one point. "It still works." Even if you   do it doubting, it works. I mean, isn't it just amazing that if you go in the weight room and lift   weights and you lift them hard enough, you'll get stronger whether you wanted to go in the   weight room or not? Because it still works if you didn't want to. Isn't that the case? Is that true? If I put my body under the right amount of stress with the right form for the   right amount of time under tension, my body will respond to that whether or not I had

[00:20:00] the feeling and the motivation that I wanted to do it. Bodily exercise profiteth little,   but godliness has great value, and it means that it still

works. Come to church, listen,   and go, "I didn't get anything out of that." Well, first of all,   that's your fault, because I study. But secondly, you don't even know that yet. What if it worked? What if it went in like a seed and it's going to come up like an oak

[00:20:30] at a later season in your life? It still works. It still works. Now, you may go through winter,   but every winter yields to spring. It still works. I can't hardly get off of point number one,   and I don't know why. There must be somebody in here who needed to be   reminded that you can do it doubting, that you can pray with chains still on your feet.

[00:21:00] You can praise with shackles still on your hands. Ask Paul and Silas. I said, "Ask Paul and Silas."   They were fastened in the inner cell. That's the hardest place to get out of. But ask Paul   and Silas. If you sing at midnight, even when you don't see anything happening, even when you   have no proof that the chains are starting to weaken... If you will worship in this situation... And I'm saying in this moment right now. I double-dog dare you to throw up your hands

[00:21:30] and open your mouth and say, "Do it, God. I praise you, God, because you're good, God, and   you're worthy, God, and you're mighty, God, and you're holy, God." And it works if you work it.   So, sometimes you have to do it doubting, and number two,   sometimes you have to do it delayed. Delayed.

[00:22:00] Do you know what I mean by delayed? God asks you to do something on this Tuesday   that is only going to make sense in two years. Or maybe I could say it like this: God tells you to pick up a snake by the tail. That is the exact wrong way. Not that I've ever picked   up snakes, although there is probably some account that says we do it every Sunday in our church,   along with our baptism waterslide that we have that I've never seen before except

[00:22:30] Photoshop. I never did it, but I know if I did it, I wouldn't do it like that. See, this is the pattern. Let me preach. This is what God is trying to show Moses. Like,   "I grab you the way I want to. I grab you in a way that doesn't   make sense. I use things that don't make sense to get your attention." Please write this down. God's sovereign plan does not always make practical sense. God's sovereign

[00:23:00] plan, the plan that he has marked out before time began... Remember, God was working this deliverance   narrative in his people's life

to foreshadow the work Jesus Christ would do on the cross. So, when Jesus would show up, he would lead not only through the cross he died on,

[00:23:30] but through the life he lived, he would lead us to freedom as our true Moses. Knowing that,   we understand that God is working things out in a way that seems weird to us. I'm at   the point in my life where I'm willing to be weird if it works. You know what I'm saying? Now, in order to grab this snake by the tail... Just imagine this. Moses is like,

[00:24:00] "All right. You want me to do...what? Okay. No." And he runs, and he resists for a little while,   but remember, great faith sometimes is doing it delayed. Okay. So, he wastes some time not   only running from the snake, but he has been 40 years running from his assignment. Forty years.   And God shows up to say, "I'm going to do it through you anyway."

[00:24:30] I break the spirit of accusation over your life that has told you it's too late. I break the   spirit of accusation over your life that says you can't get it back. I break the spirit of   condemnation over your life that says you cannot become what God has called you to be. I break   the spirit of condemnation that tries to stamp you with your worst mistake, because the life   of Moses tells me that my past mistake is not my permanent verdict. That's what it shows me.

[00:25:00] When I say, "Past mistake," I mean it could be five years ago; it could be five minutes ago,   but that will not define me, because God has a plan for me. God has a plan   for the things I did right. God has a plan for the things I did wrong.   God has a plan for my doubts just as much as God has a plan for my bold declarations of faith. Moses picks up the snake by the tail, but not at first. Moses is used as a messenger,

[00:25:30] but before he's a messenger, he's a murderer. I just want to remind you that God makes all things   beautiful in his time. Sometimes you've got to do it on a delay and just pray stuff like,   "God, I pray that you would make up for the time I wasted. God, I pray that you   would put me on an accelerated course. God, I pray that you would put me in summer school so

[00:26:00] I can graduate with all my friends. God, I pray that you will just give me the grace." And God says, "Okay," because once Moses got on the same page with God,   it only took 10 plagues for God to do what he was going to do. It's not   going to take as long as you think it's going to take. It's not going to take   everything you think it's going to take, because

sometimes God does it on a delay. That means you've got to praise him in advance in case he does it on delay,

[00:26:30] because you don't know. You don't know. The Lord anointed me to preach today that   sometimes you've got to do it on a delay. Do it on a delay. I mean, we all get stuck in   the past sometimes. I've been stuck in the past a lot lately...in a fun way, actually. I've been going around buying records, albums, LPs, vinyl. I probably bought about 300 in the

[00:27:00] last year. It's getting ridiculous. I'm going to tell you why it's getting ridiculous. Because I   already had all that stuff on my phone, and now I'm spending money on what I already subscribed to   Spotify to hear, but there's something comforting about it. So, you know, I've been buying records.

[00:27:30] Now, I don't want you to think I'm older than I am.   When I grew up, records were on the way out. We had cassette tapes, and then... Get ready to   shout. Every Boomer in the house, just shout right now. Gen X, just shout right now. Everybody make   some noise; put your hands up. If you know _____ (27:50), put your hands up. Now,   you may say to me, like the Lord said to Moses, "What is that in your hand?"

[00:28:00] Come here, Graham. Come here, come here, come here. All right. This is a boombox. And not only   that, but this is a Sanyo boombox with a cassette deck and... Everybody say, "And." Because Moses was   a Hebrew and an Egyptian. This is a cassette and CD player. This is the first CD player I ever

[00:28:30] owned, but this is not the original, because I got rid of mine because I thought it was obsolete. Sometimes you need to hang around with your old stuff,   and sometimes you need to be careful not selling something you might want to buy back later.   I went on eBay, and I found this exact model of the boombox.

[00:29:00] I plugged it in, and the lights came on, and I got excited. I put the CD in, because I've been buying   those too. I only bought about 100 of those in the last year, but I've been buying those too. I don't   know if midlife is just stressing me out to the point that I just need every escape valve. Hey,   there are worse midlife crises than CDs and records, so if I keep it to vinyl,   I'm doing very good. Tell somebody, "He's doing very good." Mm-hmm. I'm doing really good.

[00:29:30] I turned it on, and I put the CD in, and it didn't work. It didn't work. But, I mean, what   else would you expect? It has been around since

1994. Who knows what kind of devil music has been   played in this machine? The Lord shut it down. It didn't work. And just as I was about to put it up...

[00:30:00] Because it was no refunds. The seller told me that up front. Forty bucks is gone. I   remembered that just because one thing doesn't work (hold it up) doesn't mean it's worthless.   So, I went and found a cassette. I've been collecting those, too, lately. Sometimes   you've got to reach back to where God brought you from. I found a cassette tape from Jackson

[00:30:30] Memorial Baptist Church, 89...(Son, my eyes are messing up; read that for me)...8931 Highway 11,   Campobello, South Carolina, 29322. And it says, "Steven, October 29, the year 2000." (I'll tell you about Y2K later. We almost lost everything. You think the Red Sea was a miracle.

[00:31:00] Wait till I tell you about Y2K, boy, when I tell you what the Lord did for us in Y2K.) I put it in,   and at first I started to cringe. Listen to me preaching in the year 2000 in Campobello,   South Carolina. You've heard me preach in California, but you've never heard my   anointed work in Campobello. But I want you to understand that the same anointing that works

[00:31:30] in California was working in Campobello. Listen to this. Can y'all hear that? I mean, it's good enough. That's my mentality nowadays. It's good enough. Hey,   it might not be the way I like it. It might not be my personal preference. The preacher   might not be making a bit of sense to me, but it's good enough. I'm going to take some notes,   and I'm going to learn what I can from it, because praise is a privilege.

[00:32:00] It's a privilege to be in church. It is a privilege   to be in this church with you guys this morning. Yeah. Not a single "Amen," but I was preaching. About 15 people in the church,   but I was preaching. I didn't know anything I was talking about, but I was preaching. We were all   stocking up on bottled water and ramen noodles for the apocalypse to come, but I was preaching.

[00:32:30] I wonder, did the Lord want to give us a message today from this cassette tape from   a boombox that didn't work, but it did work with a word I had been preaching? Because I realized,   listening to myself preaching with a country accent in Campobello,   South Carolina, in 2026 that I have been preaching the same book for 30 years.

[00:33:00] I preached it with twang, and I preached it in small spaces, and I preached it on tapes, and I   preached it on CDs, and I preached it on podcasts, and I preached it on YouTube, and I preached it on   Roku, and I preached it on Apple TV. I've been preaching one book and believing one book for   30 years, and I came to announce it still works. I said, "It still works!" I said, "It still works!"

> [00:33:30] Faith still works. Faith still works. Grace still works. Gratitude still works.   "Hallelujah" still works. "Thank you, Jesus" still works. It still works! If   you know what I'm talking about, wave your hand and say, "It works for me."   It has been working for me a long time, and it still works. It still works. → Faith as 'it works' — mechanism without the canonical lament tradition

> [00:34:00] I've got some doubts I didn't have then, but it still works. I've got some unanswered questions,   but it still works. My faith is not having the answer; my faith is putting my hand in the hand   of a man who does. It still works. Y'all don't get it. I'm trying to say that the method has changed,   but the message is the same. It still works. I'm trying to say don't let what doesn't work   → Faith as 'it works' — mechanism without the canonical lament tradition

[00:34:30] in your life keep you from using what does, and I'm trying to say that what God gave you then   is good enough to get you through (Where's my band?) what you're going through now. So, tell somebody, "It'll work. It'll work. It'll work. It'll work."

> [00:35:00] Won't it work? I said, "Won't it work?" Not if you don't work it, if you're like, "This   is weird." Thank you. Sit down. Take the boombox with you. Take that staff with you, so when you   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:35:30] get to Egypt you can throw it on the ground and watch what it'll become. Throw it on the ground. See, now, give me the cassette tape back. I want to show this all the   way. I heard a testimony the other day. We always say... God. Help us,   Jesus. I never said I was a good dad. I never said I taught my kids important things. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:36:00] He can't open the cassette tape. How are you going to run a revival...? How are you   going to be anointed by God and you can't play a tape? Love that boy. I bleached my hair too.   My hair ain't black anymore, but my anointing still works. Okay. I'm going to tell you this,   and I'll start thinking about finishing my sermon. Tell somebody, "It still works." → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:36:30] I was amazed that the boombox still worked. I was amazed that there was   part of it that did work and part of it that didn't work, and choosing to say,   "I'm going to use what..." I was amazed when I put the tape in, and I was like, "Yo,   listen to that kid, 20 years old, hollering at those people, telling them, 'It's a privilege   to be here in church, a privilege to praise God. Amen.'" I need to bring some of that   back. I need to bring some of that country preaching back in this church. It still works. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:37:00] Well, I got a testimony that confirmed this message, because I'm always trying to make sure   I have the word the Lord wants me to deliver. Now, back in the day, you had to wait six weeks before   you could get a sermon. They had to mail it to you on tape. Now people can just watch online,   and sometimes it still takes a delay before I know how God uses a word. There was a word I preached from Exodus, chapter 4, ten years ago called Handle It.   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:37:30] Really tight skinny jeans, running around the stage, preaching on, "Pick up the snake by the   tail," because that's weird, and I was trying to say, "It's only weird till it works," you   know. Like, trusting God, holding out. "You're a virgin? That's weird." No. It works, because I'm   protecting myself, because I know the value God has put on my life. So it works. Look. Some of the   things that work in God's kingdom look completely weird to the world, but forgiveness still works. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:38:00] Even if it doesn't fix them, it will free you. Do you see what I mean? That's weird,   but it works. It's weird to grab a snake by the tail, but it works. It's weird. I was thinking   about another one. It's weird for us to give to God so that our church can do outreaches,   so that our church can reach the world, so that our church can preach the gospel. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'; Tithing/giving framed as 'weird but it works' mechanism

[00:38:30] That is weird, but you find out that God doesn't need what you have;   you need what he has when you give, and it allows you to access your faith. So,   people are like, "You give your money to that church?" "No. I give it to God   through a church." Do you understand? I'm giving this to God, and that works for me,   because it keeps me free from being mastered by money. So that's weird, but it works. I honestly always thought it was weird to put our   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'; Tithing/giving framed as 'weird but it works' mechanism

[00:39:00] sermons online. When we first started doing that, I thought that was weird,   and I thought it wouldn't work. I even made that argument. I told a brother one time,   "I don't have that gift to look into a camera and preach." You know, man, I came from Campobello. The only reason... I remembered. I listened to the tape. The only reason I preached at Campobello was   because the maintenance man at the college I was attending at the time had fixed my shower for me,   and he said, "Now that I fixed your shower, you've got to come preach at my church." I said, "Deal." → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:39:30] So, when you come from Campobello preaching, you know, like that, it's hard to get our mind around   the fact that so many people are logged on right now. I want you to put where you're watching from   on YouTube right now, and I want to do this illustration. See, the methods have changed,   but the methods... I messed that up, didn't I? The methods have changed; the message has not. Amen. And if you go on right now, people are watching from, I mean,   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:40:00] all over the world. Sometimes I get a testimony from Alabama, from Michigan,   from Denver, from San Diego, from Utah, from Missouri... that's wild, man...Orlando,   Connecticut, Texas. Y'all think I'm talking about me and preaching? I'm not. I'm talking   about you and the challenge of your life right now that you feel insufficient for. I'm trying to tell you I've always doubted what I could do. There have been times in my   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:40:30] life I preached and felt nothing worked. Do you understand me? I went back and I prayed, "God,   what even was that?" Well, 10 years ago, I was preaching this same passage. A couple of years   after that, there was a man in Greenville, South Carolina, who relayed his story to me. He was in the middle of a horrible divorce, and he had a 9mm on his coffee table. He   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:41:00] was in his apartment alone, and he didn't know what to do. He said,   "I had this weird feeling. Something told me to plug up the Apple TV that my   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:41:30] mom had brought over to my house a few days earlier, and so I did, and it felt weird." Then he said, "After I plugged it in, trying to figure out,   'Do I even want to be here?' something came up as I logged in on the screen,   and it was a purple icon that said 'Podcast.' I had never listened to a podcast. Something said,   'Click it,' and I clicked it. I clicked that purple icon that said 'Podcast,'   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:42:00] and then an orange icon came up that said 'Elevation,' and something said, 'Click it.'" Listen to me. He said, "Something said, 'Click it,'" and he clicked it. He said,   "It was a sermon of a preacher I never heard of before, saying, 'Handle it. Handle it.' And   halfway through your sermon, you said, 'You're sitting on the couch, and you're wondering,   "Do I even want to be here?" and God wanted you to know it's handled. Get up off the couch.'" → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:42:30] He said, "I got up and started walking around my apartment. I can't explain   exactly what happened that day, and I know it sounds weird, but God started   working in my life. It felt weird to plug up an Apple TV with a gun on the coffee table,   but I plugged it up." "It felt weird to reach down and grab a snake by the tail." "It feels weird for me to keep showing up even though nobody appreciates me.   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:43:00] It feels weird for me to even be in church today because, honestly,   I'm still struggling so much with my past. I can't even really focus   on what you're saying right now. It feels weird for me to believe God could use me." He said, "But I started walking around, and all I can tell you is that that day,   when I plugged in that TV and God hit me with that podcast..." It was a word that was preached   10 years ago from the exact Scripture I am preaching to you today. All I can tell you is   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:43:30] it still works. With a gun on his coffee table, the Word of God was powerful enough to say,   "I see you. I've got you. I've got something for you." And the best part of his testimony is that   he told me, today, he is a worship leader in a local church, because it still works. It works! → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:44:00] Shove somebody and say, "It works!" It has always worked, and it still works.   Come on. Clap those hands and praise God like you know that the King of glory is working in   ways you can't see. You shall live and not die! It still works! It still works. In my darkest hour,   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:44:30] it worked. In my lowest moment, it worked. In my most hopeless situation, it worked. Moses took that staff (I'm almost done), and he picked it up, and it became a staff. When   he got in front of Pharaoh, he and Aaron said, "Watch this." Boom! And it still   worked. It not only worked in private; it worked in public. It still worked. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:45:00] When Pharaoh said, "I'm not letting your people go," Moses said, "All right," and he stuck up the   staff, and hail started falling out of the sky, because no matter how much resistance you face,   it still works. When he still wouldn't let the people go, Moses pointed it, and frogs covered the   land. And when he still wouldn't let the people go, he pointed it, and the Nile became blood. But there came a moment for Moses that is like the moment most of us are in today. It goes like this.   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:45:30] You know it. The people of God have come out of Egypt. They are moving into their   freedom as sons and daughters, but they are not yet free. They have to cross a   body of water known as the Red Sea or the Sea of Reeds. As they stand at that body of water,   they hear the sound of 400 chosen chariots of Pharaoh, the hit men coming to bring them back. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:46:00] There would be no hope in this situation, even for the most well-suited army, much less millions of   slaves and runaways on foot. "What is the sound we hear behind us? We cried to the Lord to bring   us out of Egypt, and here we are looking at a Red Sea." Moses, in an effort to do crowd   control... Because this is getting out of hand quickly, as they begin to say, "Why didn't you   leave us in Egypt? Why didn't you leave us where we were? This is worse than where we came from." → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:46:30] Sometimes you get there with God. You're like, "I'm trying to do what God called me to do,   but it actually feels more difficult to do it God's way." At that very moment,   Moses gives a speech. Exodus 14. "'Do not be afraid. Stand firm and you will see the   deliverance the Lord will bring you today. The Egyptians you see today you will never see again. → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:47:00] The Lord will fight for you; you need only to be still.' Then the Lord said to Moses,   'Why are you crying out to me?'" "You know what to do. Tell the Israelites to plug in the Apple   TV. Tell the Israelites to go back to quoting the Word of God. Tell the Israelites to wash   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:47:30] their face and move on." "Raise your staff and stretch out your hand over the sea to   divide the water so that the Israelites can go through the sea on dry ground." → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:48:00] What I wanted to show you today from the Bible (leave the verse up) is that the   same staff that was on the ground was the staff that was going to work in the water.   The reason I wanted you to see that today is because the children of Israel had no   point of reference for this Red Sea, had no way of knowing how God was going to do it. Maybe you don't either, and you're standing there saying, "God, I feel like I've lost it. God,   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:48:30] I feel like this is too much. God, I've never been this way before, and I don't know what to   do." God says, "You still got that staff? You still got that Word? You still got that praise?   You still got that gift? Then stand up on your feet and lift your hands and praise your God,   because the same faith that you got at the burning bush is going to get you through this." → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:49:00] God said it'll get you through this. It'll get you through it. It'll get you through the dry season.   It'll get you through the panic attack. It'll get you through it, because it still works. It   worked on the ground; it'll work in the water. It worked when you were young; it'll work when   you're old. Somebody shout, "I've never seen the righteous forsaken." It'll work. It'll work in   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

> [00:49:30] this season. It'll work when they like you. It'll work when they hate you. It'll work when they lie   about you. It'll work when they leave you. I'm a living testimony that the Word of God still works. Hey, thank you for watching the Elevation Church YouTube. I want you to subscribe. That way you   can know when we go live and post new content. Make sure to leave me a comment. Let me know what   → Faith as mechanism: 'it works if you work it'

[00:50:00] spoke to you today, where you're watching from, and what we can pray for you about. And if you'd   like to support the ministry financially, you can click the give button now and help us continue   reaching people around the world for Jesus Christ. Thanks again. I'll see you next time.

Methodology

Axis 1 — Fidelity to Jesus's Teachings: findings flag contradictions with, tensions against, or notable absences from Jesus's direct words in the four Gospels. Reference translation: ESV.

Axis 2 — Identifiable Biases / Harmful Rhetoric: co-equal sub-rubrics for Christian nationalism (Whitehead & Perry's *Taking America Back for God*; Du Mez, *Jesus and John Wayne*; Alberta, *The Kingdom, the Power, and the Glory*), anti-Muslim framing, anti-LGBTQ framing, misogynistic framing, and anti-Jewish framing. Findings weighted by *reach × specificity × real-world harm potential*.

Axis 3 — Factual Claims & Evidence Check: empirical claims extracted from the sermon are compared against independent scholarly, journalistic, and primary sources. Each claim receives a verdict (Supported · Partially supported · Contested · Misleading · Unsupported · False) and records whether the pastor cited evidence when making the claim (a rhetorical concern distinct from the empirical verdict). No verdict is rendered without a cited source.

Axis 4 — Whole-Bible Engagement: for each major framing in the sermon, the pastor's claim is placed side-by-side with Jesus's Gospel witness and with the wider biblical canon (OT and non-Gospel NT). This surfaces cherry-picking (citing a favorable verse while ignoring hostile ones on the same topic) and unacknowledged canonical tension (presenting one biblical voice as the biblical position when the scripture itself contains disagreement). Gospel citations are in ESV; OT and non-Gospel NT citations are in ESV.

Transcript source: YouTube auto-captions (YouTube video ID ccNvwDPguNU). Auto-caption text may have minor transcription errors; quoted passages have been sanity-checked against the audio.

Report generated 2026-04-21 04:48 UTC.